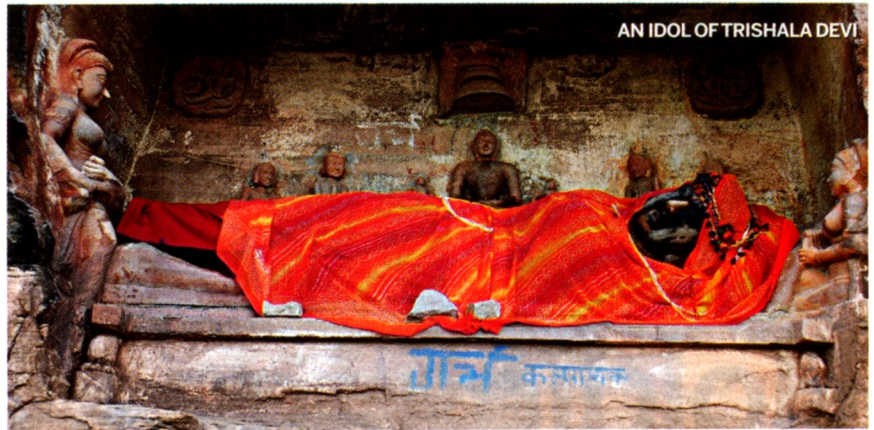


these were ancient Jain monuments inside the fort and even moved an application on November 18, in a local court. The situation turned into a comedy of sorts when the local Sahu community laid claim to the Teli Ka Mandir and the Kalhar community asserted its rights to the Saas-Bahu Mandir.

The fort complex is a veritable microcosm of India's heterogeneous heritage. Apart from such marvels as the Man Singh Palace, it also houses Gurdwara Daata Bandi Chhor in the memory of the Sikh Guru Hargobind Singh, who was incarcerated here for 12 years by the Mughal emperor Jehangir in the 17th century. In 2007, the ASI issued a notice to the Gurdwara Prabandhak Committee after it constructed an overhead water tank without permission. In its reply, the committee pleaded it was meant as a public utility. The ASI is coping with pressure with attempts to claim parts of the fort. Says assistant conservator Shashikant Rathore, "It's not just about the safety of such a monument due to the illegal construction. It is also about dated aesthetics of magnificent sandstone structures which could end up being defaced."

Disposing of a separate petition by the ASI concerning the takeover of rock-cut Jain colossi on the other side of the fort by Gopachal Siddha Kshetra Trust, the Madhya Pradesh High Court in 2004 had ordered the state Government to form a high-powered committee to deal with the numerous claims on the fort's monuments. Five years after that order, when it became clear that the Jains were becoming edgy, the Government sent a letter to Gwalior's collector on October 21, asking him to proceed with the proposal of the high-powered committee. A year-and-a-half back, a respected

seer of the community, Ajarva Sagar Ji Maharaj, had spearheaded a sit-in demanding the return of the so-called Vardhamaan Temple next to the sports ground of the famous Scindia School within the fort complex. The demand was withdrawn only after Union Minister of State for Commerce Jyotiraditya Scindia intervened. In the latest conflict though, the community is pitted against locals who reside near the foothills on the route leading up to the proposed Jain temple site. Obliquely hinting at interference from local Brahmins and Rajputs, Jain says, "They don't want us to go ahead."



Many feel these are the incipient signs of a possible Hindu-Jain friction as the Digambar sect of the community is spread right across Gwalior-Chambal and Bundelkhand regions of the state. While the umbilical ties between the two communities have been fairly strong in the past, a section of the Jain community's leadership has become very assertive of its identity over the last decade or so. The phenomenon has become visible ever since Congress chief minister Digvijay Singh, in his second stint, declared the community a minority in the state. While BJP's leaders from the community like Sunderlal Patwa had opposed

it then, they have quietly buried their opposition. "Powerful political and business interests, who are trying to establish themselves as arbiters of the community, are behind these incidents. If they have not spoken openly, it's only because they fear it would earn the ire of the Scindias who still wield considerable political clout," says a district administration official.

Gwalior is not the first attempt at such a bold political assertion in the guise of the religious rights of a minority over its heritage. In January 2006, a frenzied mob led by a section of the community's leadership had demol-

ished an ASI-protected temple in Kundalpur in Damoh that housed a 6th century idol of Lord Adinath despite the Jabalpur Bench of the high court having already ordered maintenance of status quo upon ASI petition. The ASI again moved the court that barred further activity. A committee headed by the Damoh district judge formed to look in this matter is still at work.

Such brazen flouting of law in Damoh had a significant political fallout as the sitting MLA Jayant Maliya, a Jain and a minister in Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan Cabinet, barely managed to recapture the seat by 130 votes in 2008 Assembly polls. Digvijay's declaration may have been an attempt to wean the community away from the Brahmin-Baniya political construct, but for Chouhan, the challenge is daunting as the future of a millennia-old social edifice is at stake.



“It's also about the dated aesthetics of the sandstone structures which could be defaced because of these crude attempts.”

SHASHIKANT RATHORE, Assistant Conservator, ASI